

Mother as a Superhero in Buchi Emecheta's *The Joys of Motherhood*

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Abstract

This article argues that Buchi Emecheta's *The Joys of Motherhood* engages with mothers' experiences in Africa. It reveals that a mother in Africa is always a victim of constant abuse, violence and neglect, despite her commitment to her family. Using Nnu Ego, the protagonist of the novel, as an example of a committed mother, the article engages with the sacrifices of mothers in families. It also shows how much suffering, abuse and violence a mother endures to hold on to the image of her undying love for her family. This article portrays a mother, such as Nnu Ego, who continues to endure an abusive marriage because of her irresponsible children, as a superhero, contrary to popular chauvinistic postulations that portray such a stay as a weakness. Even though this article adopts feminism as the literary theory to better understand this discourse on motherism, Buchi Emecheta's *The Joys of Motherhood* can be referred to as one of the canonical texts often deployed to better understand discourses on African feminism, where womanism and motherism are strongly featured as feminist ideologies. It uses the novel as a tool to emphasise the writer's perception of mothers' committed lifestyles and the patriarchal stereotypes that constantly try to pull them down. This article concludes that *The Joys of Motherhood* is a novel that is about how a mother, Nnu Ego, is able to recreate her personal life experience, which is characterised by tales of suffering, abuse and violence, for the benefit of her family.

Keywords: Mother, Feminism, Violence against women, Patriarchal Stereotype

Introduction

One of the functions of literature is to communicate human experience through imaginatively created stories. Buchi Emecheta's novel titled *The Joys of Motherhood* has been able to fulfil this function of literature by reflecting on the experience of mothers in patriarchal society, using Nnu Ego, the protagonist of the novel. The novel engages with how Nnu Ego's sufferings and struggles to provide for her children impact not only her family but also society at large. The novel, as well as its major character, Nnu Ego, has been the subject of many scholarly discourses, and some of these discourses have helped in the understanding of the intricacies in the lives of women. In her article on Buchi Emecheta's *The Joys of Motherhood*, Salome Nnoromele reveals that the novel has greatly impacted the discourses on African feminism (184). Collins Amartei, on the other hand, posits in his article that Buchi Emecheta's novel can be classified as belonging to radical feminism because of the way the character of Nnu Ego is presented (61). According to him, the novel has given the protagonist the image of the messiah – a person who sacrificed so much for the salvation of his children and later died for their sake. More recently, E. Palmer describes the

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novel as a reference text for womanism studies. His articles argue that Buchi Emecheta's novel investigates the complications of what it means to be a woman in African society. It shows that Nnu Ego, the protagonist of the novel, has had prosperity with motherhood, and her entire life is centred on her children and that it is on this basis that she gains the respect of the patriarchal society. Palmer explains that this was prevalent in that society because the British European administrations had taken up the governorship of African homelands and had decided to turn them into a source for raw materials and labour, and the citizens of the recently populated African countries, such as Nigeria, take involvement in conflict and transformation in their civilisations and ancestral principles (42).

Even though these studies have been able to show that Buchi Emecheta's *The Joys of Motherhood* has contributed to several ongoing discourses on feminism and womanism, they have not been able to properly engage the central character of the novel, Nnu Ego, as a superhero. Despite Collins Amartey's postulation that the character of Nnu Ego is given the image of a messiah in the novel that is close to the central argument in this article, this argument is not sustained in her article. E Palmer, on the other hand, totally refutes this claim by insinuating that the protagonist of the novel has had prospects with motherhood. The aim of this article, therefore, is to posit that Nnu Ego, the central character of the novel, is a superhero. It argues that women are elevated into the optimism of being superheroes by becoming mothers and not by remaining "women". It shows that in the mandate to be a good wife, a woman must first be a good mother. As the novel demonstrates, both Nnu Ego and Adaku, the inherited wife of Nnaife, in accordance with tradition, also suffered in Nnaife's house when they had no choice but to live together. These mothers' ability to mother a child becomes an encumbrance far superior to what virginity had been for them in their adolescence.

Mapping Previous Discourses on Buchi Emecheta's *The Joys of Motherhood*

Several studies have been carried out on Emecheta's *The Joys of Motherhood*. Among these studies is Oladele Taiwo's, who is of the view that Buchi Emecheta's *The Joys of Motherhood* is about oppressive and dominant attitudes of the customary culture which are in support and have brought about the strict instruction of daughters, girls, and women's roles as wives in society. Wives obey, respect, honour, and serve their husbands in all matters. However, this may not be viewed as the right of every man, especially men who do not cater, care, love and provide for their family (wife and children) as well as their additional family members. Thus, Nnu Ego is unable to give Nnaife the full respect that he deserves, because the head of the home is supposed to provide for the family, but Nnaife was unable to provide for his family, and Nnu Ego had to use the money from her on-and-off petty trading to supplement the insufficient income Nnaife brought home. Nnu Ego is also portrayed in the novel as a woman who knows her rights in the womanly aspect in the traditional setting and would not compromise that for any man. He argues further that the novel is not only about the injustice of women but also about the influence of colonial masters on the people, the new rules and financial directives which have turned men like Nnaife to woman-made-man laundering the white man's clothes (49), and the gentle fragmentation of traditional morals. Looking closely at the whole turn of events, the family is most affected, and it is affected intensely. Collins Amartey argues that the white man's influence contests and corrodes the collective and clique value and moral systems that once demarcated Africa. The people are unable to comprehend the forced recruitment into the army. The financial and societal hardships that raised their heads throughout and even after the war in Europe are likewise experienced in Nigeria and most suggestively in Nnu Ego's household. She has to hold the family together in Nnaife's husband's

absence, as his inadequate allowance of 20 pounds is hardly able to sustain them. Looking at the book critically, the title of the novel itself, *The Joys of Motherhood*, is satirical when observed in the light of the story. But conceivably, Buchi Emecheta seems to propose that Nnu Ego's joy is in her ability to give birth to sons, believing that will decide her motherhood, veneration, dignity and place in society. So that, in the end, it will not matter at all whether her children take care of her in her old age or not.

Philomina Steady explains that the ethnic custom of appreciating mothers, daughters and wives according to their ability to have children stands out in the novel, and most of the time not just giving birth to children but to male children. In the novel, it was greatly emphasised that male children are valued and accorded respect more than female children. Equally, Ona and Nnu Ego are mothers who experience unadorned humiliation for their first failed attempt to get pregnant. Both women are not at will to make their own choices and decisions. Frequently remaining like possessions to their fathers until a suitable marriage can be arranged for them that will be of benefit to the fathers. Regrettably for both mother and daughter, their childbearing becomes their own problem (18). For Ona, this means a tragic death in childbirth during her second pregnancy. Her body was not able to withstand the stress of such a life-threatening physical state, and she died, which was very communal between mothers in her generation. Michael Worton and Nana Wilson-Tagoe examine Nnu Ego's life after trying to give birth for a while, and once she finally gives birth to children. According to them, she loses her value, dignity and worth to her husband. Moreover, her purpose has been fulfilled, so her society and husband say. Not long afterwards, he comes home with a new wife because he feels that she is of no importance any longer, without telling her. Sooner or later, even her children whom she suffered, struggled, fought for and cared for turn against her, their mother, and neglect her in her old age and time of need - seeing as her worth was grounded wholly on her youth, health and ability to give birth.

In the novel, characters are portrayed as hoping and longing for things, but in the end, they are met with disappointment. Lilian Temu Osaka writes that the two characters whose lives mainly model the hazard of trusting in something long-standing and then obtaining devastating disillusionment are Agbadi and Nnu Ego. Agbadi falls in love with Ona, and he tries everything humanly possible and within his power; nevertheless, she remains aloof to his show of affection and advances until, eventually, by unintended circumstance, she yields and agrees to marry him. Agbadi is ecstatic, but the euphoria is short-lived. Unfortunately, Ona struggles to give him children, soon losing his favour in the process. Even though he longed for her from afar, he finds himself easily disheartened once he has selected his mate. He turns to other women when she is no longer there. Correspondingly, but much more to the extreme, Nnu Ego had familiarities with disenchantment after finally giving birth to children after years and years of trying. Seen as a woman and a wife most importantly, her very uniqueness is enfolded up in the perception of motherhood, so she accurately has everything to lose if she cannot have children. But by the time her children mature into adults, Nnu Ego has major regrets, because what she hoped for is not what she got in the end, since her children were not blessings to her in the least and remained ungrateful and neglectful of her late into her advanced years and when she needed them the most. In the end of the novel, Nnu Ego dies alone, despite the fact that she attained the apex of accomplishment of a woman by marrying into a wealthy family and giving birth to many children. E. Palmer says that Emecheta's *The Joys of Motherhood* is an attractively disastrous, ironic title used by Buchi Emecheta for the title of her novel, surrounding the multi- generational description of mothersfolk in a rustic community in Africa (40). Initially, Ona, then also her daughter Nnu Ego, learn to their greatest

disappointment that motherhood (giving birth to children), on which their whole existence has been centred in expectation up to the real event, is another of society's rip-offs. These mothers are viewed, valued and acknowledged for their ability to produce children. Daniel Okyere-Darko et al. argue that for Ona, this leads to a demoralising miscarriage, one in good physical shape, a baby girl, and then death in labour on her next attempt to try and give birth to a male child this time, hopefully. Because she was supposed to give her husband an heir. That was the situation of her mother; Nnu Ego's situation and circumstances prove much more multifaceted but correspondingly, if not more, disastrous.

Nnu Ego is portrayed as the authentic one. Having been unsuccessful in giving her first husband a child, she is ill-treated and returns to her father's house. The elimination from this experience persuades the young woman more than ever that she must demonstrate a good wife by giving her next husband many children, but this time her virginity and her pride are gone, and her expectations are much lower. She is later married to a working-class man as her second husband, Nnaife, and does give him many children as she had intended, but after the children arrive, her circumstances become, in her own contemplation, a form of captivity.

She works all day every day and every time in order to provide for these children, but she obtains no gratitude or establishment for herself. In fact, as she ages, her husband comes home with a new, fresher and younger wife whose eventual children also become Nnu Ego's responsibility. When the so-called children whom she has suffered to take care of eventually grow up, each of them turns into an insurgent with slight respect for their parents. The senior daughter, Kehinde, runs off with a young Yoruba man when she is young, not listening to her parents when they object to the man in question. Daniel Okyere-Darko et al. reveal that Nnaife, angry that the man is not worthy and will not be able to pay the money he is expecting to collect as bride price, engages in a fight with the man's father and even injures him, landing him in prison (24). Now Nnu Ego is on her own without a husband and any child at all, as all her other children have also left. Eventually, she went back to her father's house to live and lived alone there without care from anyone, and was eventually sent out into the streets, where she died alone. She was later acknowledged after her death and later honoured by her adult children in a fertility shrine for the local mothers; she becomes the personification of betrayal. All that Nnu Ego, the protagonist of the novel, believed about the joys of motherhood was methodically reviewed in the certainty of her experience of motherhood, yet her children still egotistically believe that she had accomplished the definitive position anticipated by mothers in their culture. Salome Nnoromele notes that Nnu Ego can be viewed as the perfect wife, mother, and daughter, who was obedient and submissive to the male figures in her life, even when she was not supposed to undermine the circumstances in which she lived, but she was always prompted to do so, as a form of respect and the following of tradition that has already laid down the rules and regulations by which a woman is to be governed (187). And even as Nnu Ego was the perfect wife who did everything that was accorded to her, she was still neglected not only by her husband but by her children too. When she had realised that giving birth to children was not the way to gain respect and self-value, she rehabilitated her mind about valuing herself according to fertility, but Nnu Ego is celebrated amongst her people for that very principle once again against her will.

Conceptualising Motherhood as Superhero

The Joys of Motherhood is one of Buchi Emecheta's best and well-known works. Through her novel, Emecheta laid emphasis on and criticised colonialism and customs, and how they impact

the lives of mothers, using Nnu Ego, the protagonist of the novel and her family. *The Joys of Motherhood* is a novel that portrays a mother's struggle in a patriarchal society where she not only faces problems from her husband but also from her children and society at large. The novel actually takes off with the protagonist of the novel, Nnu Ego, trying to commit suicide. At the beginning of the novel, we see Nnu Ego running to the bridge, where she has already made up her mind to jump into the river and eventually die.

Nnu Ego backed out of the room, her eyes unfocused and glazed, looking into vacancy. Her feet were light, and she walked as if in a daze, not conscious of using those feet. She collided with the door, moved away from it and across the veranda, onto the green grass that formed part of the servant quarters. The grass was moist with dew under her bare feet. Her whole body felt the hazy mist in the air, and part of her felt herself brushing against the white masters washing on the line. This made her whirl round with a jerk, like a puppet reaching the end of its string. She now faced the road, having decided to use her eyes, her front instead of her back. She ran, her feet lighter still, as if her eyes, now that she was using them, gave her extra lightness. She ran, past the master's bungalow, past the side garden, and shot into the untarred gravel road[...] she would soon be there, she told herself. It would all soon be over, right there under the deep water that ran below Carter Bridge. (7-9)

The novel then takes us through a flashback as to what led Nnu Ego to the bridge in the first place. We learnt that Nnu Ego's first-born child had just died. She is devastated and sees no reason at all to live anymore and wants to end her life. She wants to meet her *chi* and ask her what she has done exactly to deserve this. She believes her *chi* is a woman, a slave woman at that, and she wants to ask her why she is making her suffer. In accordance with the Igbo culture, a *chi* is a private deity that has the ability to impact one's life positively or negatively. Nnu Ego sees her *chi* as the spirit that is behind her inability to get pregnant in her first marriage. The morning after she left her first marriage, she has a dream in which her *chi* offers her a baby, but she must cross a stream to get it. As she tries to cross, the waters rise, threatening to drown her, and her *chi* mocks her. Because of her inability to bear a child, she started taking care of the children of the younger wives of the house. And as a result, she received a lot of criticism from other mothers who were of the view that she should just wait for her own child instead of taking care of others' own. On one occasion, one of the younger wives of the house left her baby with Nnu Ego and went to meet their husband and didn't come back for her baby. Since the baby was hungry and needed to be fed, Nnu Ego fed the baby with her own breast milk. She lay with the baby and breastfed him until they both drifted to sleep.

Thereafter, she cried to her *chi*, telling her that she had breast milk and could take care of a child and that she should bless her with a child. On the evening of one day, the second wife of their husband was giving birth. Nnu Ego, having been tired of watching her mate conceive and give birth while she had not, took the baby while she thought no one was looking, went into her inner room and started appealing to the baby to be hers or send for his other friends from the other world. Not knowing that their husband was watching her, she put the child to her breast, and the next thing she felt was a double blow from behind. Because of this incident, Nnu Ego's father came to take her away and then treated her for the bruises she had sustained as a result of the beating from her husband. Nnu Ego still loved her husband but did not want to return to his house. So her father started looking for another husband for her, and then, after consulting his friends, he decided to marry her off to the Owulum family. After that decision, he went and returned the bride price to

Nnu Ego's former husband. The next day, Nnu Ego was on her way to Lagos to meet her new husband: "the journey from Ibuza to Lagos took Nnu Ego and the elder Owulum brother four days" (40). After being introduced to her new husband, Nnu Ego did not like him but prayed that if he could make her pregnant, she would put the fact that she did not like him aside and be faithful to him for the rest of her life.

"O my chi, she prayed as she rolled painfully to her other side on the raffia bed. "O my dead mother, please make this dream come true, then I will respect this man, I will be his faithful wife and put up with his crude ways and ugly appearance. Oh please help me, all you my ancestors. If I should become pregnant by him... (44-45)

A few months afterwards, Nnu Ego became pregnant, and her husband, Nnaife, told her that he had not married her in the church and so she should keep it a secret because if she did not, he would lose his job. Nine months afterwards, in the middle of the night, Nnu Ego went into labour and gave birth to a baby boy which she called Ngozi. He was her pride because she made her a mother and a woman after her first failed marriage. After the birth, they called and told the men about it, and they came out and started celebrating the good news. One morning, after doing her normal chores, she decided to go to her stall for that day, but when she went to where she left Ngozi, she found him dead.

After her child, Ngozi, died, she tried to commit suicide by jumping off a bridge, but a friend of her husband, Nwakusor, saw her and convinced her that taking her life was not the solution to the problem. After being talked to and convinced that committing suicide is not the way, she decided to live a new life and hope for more out of life than just children. She decided to try and get pregnant again, and this time she did get pregnant. In her dream, she saw an abandoned and dirty baby by the side of the same stream which she had dreamed of before. Out of kindness, she picked up the baby; though she was irritated at how dirty the baby was, she picked up the baby and washed it clean in the stream. Her chi then came along and told her that she could have this baby if she wanted it, and not only that, but she could have all the dirty babies if she wanted. Ever since Nnu Ego had that dream, she never again had a problem with getting pregnant. In fact, she gave birth to one baby after another, including giving birth to a set of twin's girls. But even after having the children she had longed for all this while, her life was not easy. The joy of having children is dominated by the constant need to feed, clothe and educate them. With little or no help from her husband, Nnaife, Nnu Ego must continuously struggle to take care of her many children. In theory, it should be easy to perform that task, since her income from her petty trading was able to supplement Nnaife's income, providing sufficient income to cover the cost of necessities and education. But her husband has a predisposition to drink, to father yet more children with junior wives, and to rely on the income of his wives to cover for his shortfall. Nnu Ego and Adaku refuse to cook for their husband, Nnaife, until he provides them with the income to do so and take care of the family, but Nnaife is heartless; Nnu Ego is soon hit with the realisation that she is enslaving herself because of the love and care she has for her children. Nnaife, her husband, is recruited into the Western British military and shipped off to fight in World War II. In the midst of the commotion at home and with the taking care of her children, she heard that her father was seriously ill, and so she took her children to Ibuza to see her father: "Oh, father, I did no imagine [...] Why I did not come earlier? Look, look at my children, father. I have sons and daughters [...] The children-oh, father, father." As she and her father sat to talk at night, he told her stories about her childhood and during one of those occasions, he passed away

After the passing of her father, she had to conduct a funeral service for him because he was a great man in Ibuza. At the conclusion of the funeral of her late father, Nnu Ego stayed in their home town for a while and then returned to Lagos months later, only to find out that Adaku, her husband's second wife, had done well for herself. Her business is flourishing, and Nnu Ego, who had just returned from her father's funeral, must now struggle to begin her business again in order to feed and care for her children, since she receives no help from her husband. Nnu Ego is jealous and angry that she has to struggle to do all these by herself without the help of anyone, and one day when a relative of Adaku comes by, Nnu Ego is ashamed of her worn-out clothing, and so envious of the other woman's ostensible wealth, that she treats her offensively.

This news did not sit well with Adaku as she called for a meeting where the character Nnu Ego exhibited will be judged, but to her astonishment, the men of the family sided with Nnu Ego, the senior wife. Adaku then realise that she will never have the power or the status of the senior wife, and she decides to leave her husband's house and follow her dreams and passion. Nnu Ego's first son, Oshia, travels to America so he can be successful and help out his younger siblings, but on getting there, he sees life in a new way and now abandons and neglects them. As a result of his actions, Kehinde is younger sister runs away with a Yoruba man. His parents, Nnu Ego and Nnaife, have both put all their hope on him as the oldest son. They have invested everything they had to give him a good education, trusting that he will get a good job after he graduates and that he will help them to educate his younger siblings. But Oshia had other ideas, as his education among well-to-do students has taught him to be self-centred, and he no longer feels that he should support or give any form of help to his family. This disenchantment and overwhelming news leaves Nnaife irritated and hostile, and Nnu Ego anxious and worried, uncertain of how she is going to educate the rest of her children.

This was not the only issue that Nnu Ego had to deal with, as she was just informed that one of her daughters. Kehinde has run away to marry the son of the local butcher, a Yoruba man. And according to their tradition, no girl from Ibuza marries a Yoruba; in fact, no girl from Ibuza was allowed to marry a mother Ibo from outside then. Hot Kehinde has broken the law and has gone and done it: "Father, I want to marry and live with Ladipo, the butcher's son. I don't want an Ibuze inan! "Kehinde means we don't know where she is" (204, 208). By this news, Nnaife is so infuriated that he takes his sword and goes to attack the butcher's household in the middle of the night. He wounds one of the young men in the family and is arrested. Nnaife was arrested despite the pleading of his own daughter and people around. He is sent to jail and charged in court. At his trial, his wife, Nnu Ego, tries to justify his anger by trying to explain that everyone, including her husband, should always get some returns from their investment in their children, but tactlessly she only flourishes in making known to the court that Nnaife is an addicted drunk who has done nothing to provide for his children. As a result of this, Nnaife goes to jail, but not before he made it clear that he hates his wife, Nnu Ego. Nnu Ego, realising that with her husband in prison, her marriage was over, decided to go home to Ibuza to live her remaining days.

After her husband went to jail and nothing more to do in Lagos since she had done what was expected of a mother for her children, she decided to go to her hometown to spend the remaining days of her life. When she was about to embark on her journey, she had a lot of well-wishers who came to say goodbye to her at the motor park, but on her arrival in her hometown, no one called to check up on her or even visited her. After a while, Nnu Ego died alone in Ibuza, with none of the children she had suffered and struggled to take care of by her side. Despite the fact that she had

done everything for her many children during her entire life, no one was there for her in her time of need. After Nnu go dies, her children now came to Ibuza, including her first son and threw her an extravagant funeral and built a shrine where offspring can come to pray and ask her to bless them with children. Nnu Ego refuses to answer prayers for children.

The protagonist of the novel Nnu Ego is a pictogram of all the pleasures, anguish, hopelessness and eventual disillusionment of widespread motherhood. Buchi Emecheta saves no detail or determination in trying to portray her as a daughter, woman, and a mother whose love, sacrifices, duty and obligation towards her children eventually lead her to stumble into wretched deficiency, poverty, calamity and mockery from her husband, his people and neighbours. The traditional, custom and cultural potentials that a woman's infinite joy and worth are determined by her ability to give birth to children. And in some cases, the ability to give birth to male children. In the novel, as it is clearly portrayed, Nnu Ego's Motherhood places so much burden on her, as she is rejected and maltreated in her first marriage to Amatokwu for not being able to give birth to a child. Her desolation is profound as she is sent from her birthplace to Ibuza, which is located in the South-eastern part of Nigeria, to Lagos, the capital of Nigeria, to be married for the second time to a different man whose life was based in Lagos, Nnaife. His life and occupation were for the white masters; he was an overweight man who washed the clothes of Dr Meers and his wife. And the sight that Nnu Ego saw was not what she expected, and she was highly disappointed at the sight of her new husband, as he was somehow amusing. Undermining all his funny-looking stature and status, he was able to wipe the tears from Nnu Ego's eyes as he made her a mother. And that was to his credit. Nnaife was the father in a swift sequence to all of Nnu Ego's children, as a result, bringing to realisation her one true desire of becoming a mother. Her labours, among thrilling disappointments, only assist in climaxing her joy in a magnificent forthcoming life that her children, predominantly her sons, will make promising.

Conclusion

In Buchi Emecheta's *The Joys of Motherhood*, the author makes essential use of melodramatic irony and periodic narrative style to portray and point out the dissatisfactions of Nnu Ego in every single characteristic of her stopovers in life. As well as the betrayal of her children, most especially her sons, in whom she put most of her hopes, as they neglected her in her old age and made all her laid plans come to nothing; the sons in whom she had put her trust, Oshia and his brother Adim, left Nigeria for Canada and America, respectively, to further educate themselves and never once sent money nor wrote to find out how the family was doing; neither did they send money for the family to live, knowing full well that the family was living in poverty. At the end of the novel, she is lonely with her husband in jail and all her children living their individual lives, not caring about her well-being; her sanity starts to give way.

If close attention is paid, there is never a thought or a mind to educate her set of twin daughters. The daughters were seen as an investment in which they would collect the money they sent in taking care of them on their wedding day. And so the parents always looked for respectful and well-to-do men for their children to marry, in which such men will bring a good bride price, which would most of the time go towards the education of their brothers: Nnu Ego assumes that her sons will be her saviour when she is advanced in age, and they will provide all the things she needs in life. Another irony about the book is Adaka Nnaites' late brother's wife that he inherited because of their custom and tradition, makes more money trading, and her expensive life is used to highlight Nnu Ego's poverty. But even later in the novel, we meant to see that she too leaves the house with

her two daughters when she is told by the family members of the family that she can never be anything more than the second wife and cannot be counted among mothers because she does not have a male child. Realising that educating a girl child has a lot of benefits for the prospect, Adaku can break away from tradition and educate her two girls, but Nnu Ego still clings to tradition, and as a result she is caught between two often belligerents, and when determination comes it is at the expense of her contentment and deceptions.

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